

EYEWITNESS July 21, 1861

First Encounter

United States and Confederate forces met for the first time at Bull Run. With local Washingtonians watching from a nearby hill, the untested armies fought chaotically. Toward the end of the day, the Confederates, fresh with reinforcements, gained the advantage and routed the Union lines. As they scattered, frantically retreating Northern soldiers were impeded by onlookers, adding to their sense of humiliation.

“The political hostilities of a generation were now face to face with weapons instead of words. Defeat to either side would be a deep mortification, but defeat to the South must turn its claim of independence into an empty vaunt ...

SUNDAY, July 21st, bearing the fate of the new-born Confederacy, broke brightly over the fields and woods that held the hostile forces ... We found the commanders resolutely stemming the further flight of the routed forces, but vainly endeavoring to restore order, and our own efforts were as futile. Every segment of line we succeeded in forming was again dissolved while another was being formed; more than two thousand men were shouting ... their voices mingling with the noise of the shells hurtling through the trees overhead, and all word of command drowned in the confusion and uproar.”

GENERAL P. G. T. BEAUREGARD, FROM *BATTLES AND LEADERS OF THE CIVIL WAR*, 1887

“A perfect hail storm of bullets, round shot and shell was poured upon us, tearing through our ranks and scattering death and confusion everywhere ... As I emerged from the woods I saw a bomb shell strike a man in the breast and literally tear him to pieces ... As we had nothing but infantry to fight against their batteries, the command was given to retreat ...

As we gained the cover of the woods the stampede became even more frightful, for the baggage wagons and ambulances became entangled with the artillery and rendered the scene even more dreadful than the battle, while the plunging of the horses broke the lines of our infantry, and prevented any